Paper II · Unit II · Topic 5 — Supplement: Peasant Sanghams, Women, Razakars and Historical Evidence

Status: Original substantive partial depth repair, 25 October 2026. The original published PDF remains byte-identical and does not yet include this supplement. This is not an independent academic approval and does not imply that the older chapter is fully rewritten.

1. Why village sanghams mattered beyond protest slogans

The Telangana peasant struggle cannot be understood only as a confrontation between the Nizam and a political party. In parts of rural Telangana, daily authority was exercised through landholding, tenancy, debt, revenue extraction and village intermediaries. A person might face coercion not from a distant palace official but from a locally dominant family controlling land, access to credit and customary labour obligations. Village sanghams mattered because they created a collective institution through which individuals could resist demands that were difficult to challenge alone. A tenant protesting an eviction in isolation risked retaliation; a village association could organise witnesses, coordinate petitions, mobilise labour and negotiate from a stronger position.

The organisational mechanism was cumulative. Meetings turned private grievances into shared demands. Cadres helped explain why a levy or compulsory service could be challenged. Collective refusal increased the cost of coercion. Where conflict intensified, some sanghams became linked to armed squads and alternative village authority. These were not identical phases or uniform practices across every district. It is inaccurate to say that every sangham exercised the same degree of control or that all villagers welcomed its actions. Local class relations, caste hierarchies and the presence of state forces shaped the possibilities of mobilisation. A careful account distinguishes the stated programme of land and labour reform from evidence of what changed in particular villages.

For mains writing, show how social organisation converted material grievance into political power: insecure tenancy → association → collective bargaining → confrontation with landlord or state coercion → wider agrarian movement. Then discuss limits: uneven participation, coercion during conflict, differences between political leadership and local initiatives, and the difficulty of reconstructing village-level outcomes from partisan accounts. This yields a fuller explanation than a list of leaders and dates.

2. Women as organisers, workers and political actors

Women's participation in the Telangana struggle was not confined to a few celebrated personalities. Agricultural labourers and cultivators could contribute food, shelter, information, movement between villages and the maintenance of networks when male activists were arrested or underground. Some women engaged in direct political organisation and resistance. Their roles challenged expectations about mobility and public speech, but their labour was also shaped by class, caste, household responsibility and the dangers of repression. Treating women as merely 'helpers' hides the logistical and political work that made sustained mobilisation possible.

At the same time, participation in a radical movement did not automatically abolish gender inequality. Women's political agency could coexist with unequal domestic burdens, exclusion from formal leadership and exposure to sexual violence. Historical sources often privilege the names of male commanders and party leaders; oral histories and women's testimonies can reveal experiences missing from official reports. Yet oral testimony must be interpreted with the same care as written records: memory can preserve suppressed experience while also reflecting later political language and the passage of time. Cross-checking testimonies against dates, places and independent accounts strengthens rather than weakens the history.

An exam answer should organise the discussion under economic contribution, communication networks, political leadership, risks and post-conflict limitations. This allows an evaluative conclusion: the struggle opened spaces for women's collective action but did not erase entrenched patriarchy. A historically sensitive approach avoids both romanticising complete emancipation and dismissing women's agency because formal leadership remained unequal.

3. Razakars, the state and the danger of communal simplification

The Razakar organisation, associated with the Majlis-e-Ittehadul-Muslimeen under Qasim Razvi, became a major coercive actor during the late 1940s crisis. However, the Razakars were not synonymous with every Muslim resident of Hyderabad, nor were they identical to all branches of the Nizam's formal administration. Many Muslims held differing political views, and agrarian conflicts cut across religious lines. Describing the conflict as simply 'Hindus versus Muslims' erases struggles over tenancy, forced labour, state authority and political representation. It also distorts the diversity of Hyderabad society.

The peasant armed struggle, the anti-Razakar mobilisation and India's September 1948 military intervention overlapped in time but had different immediate aims and organisational structures. Some peasant activists sought land redistribution and resistance to landlord domination; other political actors emphasised accession to India, civil liberties or the end of princely autocracy. These agendas could converge against coercion without becoming identical. After integration, the relationship between the Indian state and communist-led armed struggle also changed, showing why the movement cannot be reduced to a single victory narrative ending in September 1948.

When assessing violence, identify the actor, date, location and type of evidence. A retrospective estimate of casualties or armed strength should not be presented as an exact official total unless its method and coverage are known. The Government of India's Srikrishna Committee report and Telangana education materials offer later syntheses; original police files, contemporary press, party records and survivor testimonies may disagree. The appropriate conclusion is that multiple coercive systems and political objectives operated in the same crisis, and historical explanation must separate them before drawing causal connections.

4. A model evidence audit for the 1946–51 struggle

Suppose a textbook claims that a named village was liberated on a particular date, a fixed acreage was redistributed, and every resident supported the sangham. These are three different kinds of propositions. The date requires a contemporaneous event record; acreage requires land registers or a carefully explained estimate; universal support requires evidence that includes dissenting residents, not only organisers' memoirs. If such records are unavailable, write that the movement exercised influence or redistributed land in some areas, with the scale disputed. This is not evasive: it protects the reader from treating political memory as a census.

A second example concerns the 1948 integration. Indian military action changed Hyderabad's sovereignty and brought the princely regime to an end, but it did not instantly settle tenancy, caste inequality or communist-led armed mobilisation. Administrative transition, land reform and security operations unfolded over different timelines. A strong comparison distinguishes the 1946 turning point associated with Doddi Komaraiah, the 1947–48 accession crisis and the later withdrawal of the communist armed struggle. The causes, participants and outcomes overlap without collapsing into one event.

Finally, contrast an institutional source with a commemorative source. A government anniversary statement can reliably show how the state remembers a movement today; it does not prove the precise words spoken by an activist decades earlier. A judicial or administrative record may preserve an official viewpoint but omit experiences of landless labourers. Historical confidence grows when independent types of evidence converge. The student should therefore write under background, social causes, organisation, conflict, gender, outcomes and source limitations, with a conclusion that acknowledges both emancipatory demands and the human costs of violence.

Source-audit leads (not proof of every village-level detail): Government of India, Ministry of Home Affairs, Committee for Consultations on the Situation in Andhra Pradesh report, 2010; Telangana SCERT Class 7 Social Studies; Telangana State Archives and Research Institute. Independent academic review and direct archival verification remain open.